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Director of Health Security Scientific Research

UK Health Security Agency

Apply before 11:55 pm on Thursday 16th July 2026



Reference number

467446

Salary

£100,000 - £162,500

per annum, pro rata

A Civil Service Pension with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Job grade

SCS Pay Band 2

Contract type

Permanent
Secondment

Length of employment

Permanent

Type of role

Science
Senior leadership

Working pattern

Flexible working, Full-time, Job share, Part-time

Number of jobs available

1

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Location

We offer flexible working opportunities at UKHSA and operate using a hybrid working model where business needs allow. This provides us with greater

flexibility about how and where we work, for our workforce to thrive and to maximise our organisational efficiency. As a hybrid worker, you will be expected to spend a minimum of 60% of your contractual working hours (approximately 3 days a week pro rata, (averaged over a month) working at one of UKHSA's core locations (Birmingham, Leeds, Liverpool, and London - Canary Wharf) or at one of our scientific campus sites (Colindale, Porton and Chilton). In exceptional circumstances you may also be based in one of UKHSA supporting hubs, or health protection operation centres. Whilst the role can be based at any site, there will be a need to travel regularly to London and Porton Down

About the job

Job summary

This is a high profile, challenging and rewarding leadership role at UKHSA with the ability to make a significant impact on the organisation's future direction.

The Director of Health Security Scientific Research provides national leadership for UKHSA's research portfolio, ensuring that scientific activity across the organisation is high-quality, ethically governed, strategically aligned and impactful.

Job description

The role leads UKHSA's teams delivering specialist laboratory capabilities as well as behavioural science, evaluation and epidemiology.

The Director is accountable for high-hazard infectious disease work and vaccine-related research, for the scientific performance of key laboratory research teams, and for the safe and effective operation of specialist facilities, including our extensive high-containment infrastructure. They lead the organisation's research governance, manage relationships with research funders, and ensure strong systems for research information, visibility and communication. The Director also oversees the knowledge and library service, ensuring rapid access to evidence across UKHSA, and works closely

with the external research community including the Health Protection Research Units.

Working with fellow directors in the Chief Scientific Officer group, they shape research strategy, integrate scientific services, strengthen partnerships, build workforce capability and lead the development of research capacity that supports UKHSA's public health mission.

Key responsibilities will include:

Leadership & Strategy: Provide overall direction and accountability for the Directorate, setting strategic priorities within UKHSA's framework and leading change, succession planning, and resilience.

Scientific & Laboratory Excellence: Ensure all scientific and research activity is internationally leading and delivered with the highest standards of research, integrity, ethics, clinical governance, and statutory compliance, including maintaining relevant accreditation and validation.

Workforce Development: Build and sustain a skilled, safe, and motivated workforce through recruitment, retention, training and career development, ensuring health and safety standards remain paramount.

Partnerships & Engagement: Strengthen collaborations with NHS, academia, industry, and global health organisations, delivering UKHSA's international commitments and supporting commissioned services.

Governance & Performance: Oversee quality systems, data reporting, and business continuity, ensuring outputs are delivered on time, within budget, and to the highest standards of efficiency and effectiveness.

Finance & Operations: Act as budget holder, accountable for financial performance, resource allocation, and continuous improvement of directorate operations.

Group and Corporate Responsibilities: Play a full and active role in the leadership of CSO Group, the work of the Directors' Group across UKHSA and in representing UKHSA across government.

Please see candidate pack for more information.

Person specification

It is important through your CV and Statement of Suitability that you provide evidence and examples of proven experience of these selection criteria.

To be successful in this role you will have a strong scientific track record, with clear evidence of science leadership drawn from academia, public sector research, the healthcare sector, or industry. Your career path will have included becoming professionally qualified in a scientific or health discipline to an essential minimum of PhD level (or other equivalent professional qualification). You will need to be an exceptional leader with proven senior management experience and demonstrable expertise in delivering complex scientific programmes in areas that are core to UKHSA's mission, such as infectious disease, radiation protection, toxicology or epidemiology. As the UKHSA is a category 1 responder for the UK, you will be comfortable working under pressure and have a proven track record of making critical decisions in demanding circumstances. In addition, you also need to be able to demonstrate your capability and potential against the following criteria:

Essential

Strong leadership across complex scientific portfolios and multidisciplinary teams.

Deep understanding of scientific research related to one or more of UKHSA's core scientific areas such as microbiology, vaccinology or chemical/radiological threats. Comprehensive knowledge of the methods and management of public health scientific research, alongside substantial expertise and a proven track record in leading research in microbiology, vaccinology, or allied disciplines.

Demonstrable track record in maintaining the highest standards of laboratory health & safety and compliance with relevant regulations governing areas such as animal use or human tissue work.

Proven ability to manage change and motivate teams.

Financial and commercial acumen, including oversight of budgets, revenue, and capital projects.

Excellent communication skills and a strong track record in national and international collaboration.

Desirable

Senior-level experience managing operational services in health or science organisations.

Experience of working at, or managing, high-containment scientific facilities

Experience in providing advice to underpin policy development and implementation.

Experience of working with industry, academia, and government

Benefits

Alongside your salary of £100,000, UK Health Security Agency contributes £28,970 towards you being a member of the Civil Service Defined Benefit Pension scheme. [Find out what benefits a Civil Service Pension provides \(opens in a new window\)](#).

Learning and development tailored to your role

An environment with flexible working options

A culture encouraging inclusion and diversity

A [Civil Service pension](#) with an employer contribution of 28.97%

Things you need to know

Artificial intelligence

Artificial intelligence can be a useful tool to support your application, however, all examples and statements provided must be truthful, factually accurate and taken directly from your own experience. Where plagiarism has been identified (presenting the ideas and experiences of others, or generated by artificial intelligence, as your own) applications may be withdrawn and internal candidates may be subject to disciplinary action. Please see our [candidate guidance \(opens in a new window\)](#) for more information on appropriate and inappropriate use.

Selection process details

Stage 1: Application & Sift

At sift stage you will be assessed against the essential criteria within the Person Specification section listed in the candidate pack.

You will be required to complete the following:

An application form setting out your career history, with key responsibilities and achievements and relevant professional qualifications. Please ensure you have provided reasons for any gaps within the last two years. The application form needs the same information as a standard CV.

A supporting Statement (up to 1500 words) explaining how you consider your personal skills, qualities and experience provide evidence of your suitability for the role, with particular reference to the essential criteria in the person specification.

You will receive a joint score for your application form and statement.

Please note feedback will not be provided at this stage.

Stage 2: Assessments

If you are shortlisted, you will be asked to take part in an Independent Leadership Assessment (ILA) which will include psychometric tests. An ILA is a 90-minute session with an occupational psychologist aimed at gaining an understanding of your preferred behavioural style in the workplace. The assessment will be informed by online psychometric assessments you will have completed beforehand, the results of which will be explored as a part of the discussion during the session. After the ILA is completed, the assessor will formulate a narrative report which is given to the panel prior to your formal interview. The assessment will take place online between the sift stage and interview. These assessments will not result in a pass or fail decision. Rather, they are designed to support the panel's decision making and highlight areas for the panel to explore further at interview.

Stage 3: Interview

You will be invited to a face-to-face interview. In exceptional circumstances, we may be able to offer a remote interview.

Interviews to be held at UK Health Security Agency, 10 South Colonnade, London E14 4PU.

Interviews are planned for early September please note these dates are subject to change.

During the interview we will assess you against **essential criteria**.

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

External

Open to all external applicants (anyone) from outside the Civil Service (including internal applicants).

Security clearance

This role requires Developed Vetting (DV) clearance. If not already held, the successful candidate can start the role once Security Check (SC) clearance has been obtained, but continued employment is dependent on obtaining and maintaining DV level clearance which must be initiated within the first 3 months of an agreed start date.

For meaningful National Security Vetting checks to be carried out individuals need to have lived in the UK for a sufficient period of time. You should normally have been resident in the United Kingdom for the last 10 years as the role requires Developed Vetting (DV) clearance.) UK residency less than the outlined periods may not necessarily bar you from gaining national security vetting and applicants should contact the Vacancy Holder/Recruiting Manager listed in the advert for further advice.

Salary Information

If you are successful at interview, and are moving from another government department, NHS, or Local Authority, the relevant starting salary principles for level transfers or promotions will apply. Otherwise, roles are offered at the pay scale minimum for the grade, but in exceptional circumstances there may be flexibility if you are able to demonstrate you are already in receipt of an existing, higher salary. Pay increases are through the relevant annual pay award for the role and terms.

Future location

UKHSA is investing in a new state-of-the-art National Biosecurity Centre in Harlow, Essex, which will eventually bring together teams currently based at Canary Wharf, Colindale and Porton Down. For more details, please see: [Huge biosecurity centre investment to boost pandemic protection - GOV.UK.](#)

The new facilities will start becoming operational in the mid-2030s, with full completion by 2038. Staff will move in phases as facilities become available. If you're appointed to a role currently based at Canary Wharf, Colindale or Porton Down, please note that we'll continue investing in these sites for the next decade. As we get closer to the transition, we'll provide full information about relocation support available to staff.

Reasonable Adjustments

The Civil Service is committed to making sure that our selection methods are fair to

everyone. To help you during the recruitment process, we will consider any reasonable adjustments that could help you. An adjustment is a change to the recruitment process or an adjustment at work. This is separate to the Disability Confident Scheme. If you need an adjustment to be made at any point during the recruitment process you should contact the recruitment team in confidence as soon as possible to discuss your needs. You can find out more information about reasonable adjustments across the Civil Service here: <https://www.civil-service-careers.gov.uk/reasonable-adjustments/>

International Police check

If you have spent more than 6 months abroad over the last 3 years you may need an International Police Check. This would not necessarily have to be in a single block, and it could be time accrued over that period.

Internal Fraud Check

If successful for this role as one aspect of pre-employment screening, applicant's personal details - name, national insurance number and date of birth - will be checked against the Cabinet Office Internal Fraud Hub, and anyone included on the database will be refused employment unless they can show exceptional circumstances. Currently this is only for external candidates to the Civil Service.

Feedback will only be provided if you attend an interview or assessment.

This role has a minimum assignment duration of 3 years. An assignment duration is the period of time a Senior Civil Servant is expected to remain in the same post to enable them to deliver on the agreed key business outcomes. The assignment duration also supports your career through building your depth of expertise.

As part of accepting this role you will be agreeing to the expected assignment duration set out above. This will not result in a contractual change to your terms and conditions. Please note this is an expectation only, it is not something which is written into your terms and conditions or indeed which the employing organisation or you are bound by. It will depend on your personal circumstances at a particular time and business needs, for example, would not preclude any absence like family friendly leave. It is nonetheless an important expectation, which is why we ask you to confirm you agree to the assignment duration set out above.

Security

Successful candidates must undergo a criminal record check.

Successful candidates must meet the security requirements before they can be appointed. The level of security needed is [developed vetting \(opens in a new window\)](#).

[See our vetting charter \(opens in a new window\)](#).

People working with government assets must complete [baseline personnel security standard \(opens in new window\)](#) checks.

Nationality requirements

This job is broadly open to the following groups:

- UK nationals

- nationals of the Republic of Ireland

- nationals of Commonwealth countries who have the right to work in the UK

- nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities with settled or pre-settled status under the [European Union Settlement Scheme \(EUSS\) \(opens in a new window\)](#)

nationals of the EU, Switzerland, Norway, Iceland or Liechtenstein and family members of those nationalities who have made a valid application for settled or pre-settled status under the European Union Settlement Scheme (EUSS)

individuals with limited leave to remain or indefinite leave to remain who were eligible to apply for EUSS on or before 31 December 2020

Turkish nationals, and certain family members of Turkish nationals, who have accrued the right to work in the Civil Service

[Further information on nationality requirements \(opens in a new window\)](#)

Working for the Civil Service

The [Civil Service Code \(opens in a new window\)](#) sets out the standards of behaviour expected of civil servants.

We recruit by merit on the basis of fair and open competition, as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's [recruitment principles \(opens in a new window\)](#).

The Civil Service embraces diversity and promotes equal opportunities. As such, we run a Disability Confident Scheme (DCS) for candidates with disabilities who meet the minimum selection criteria.

Diversity and Inclusion

The Civil Service is committed to attract, retain and invest in talent wherever it is found. To learn more please see the [Civil Service People Plan \(opens in a new window\)](#) and the [Civil Service Diversity and Inclusion Strategy \(opens in a new window\)](#).

Apply and further information

This vacancy is part of the [Great Place to Work for Veterans \(opens in a new window\)](#) initiative.

Once this job has closed, the job advert will no longer be available. You may want to save a copy for your records.

Contact point for applicants

Job contact :

Name : Robin May

Email : CSOPrivateOffice@ukhsa.gov.uk

Recruitment team

Email : SCS.MDrecruitment@ukhsa.gov.uk

Further information

The law requires that selection for appointment to the Civil Service is on merit on the basis of fair and open competition as outlined in the Civil Service Commission's Recruitment Principles. If you feel your application has not been treated in accordance with the Recruitment Principles, and you wish to make a complaint, in the first instance, you should contact the UKHSA Complaints team via email at: Complaints@ukhsa.gov.uk. If you are not satisfied with the response you receive from the Department, you can contact the Civil Service Commission. Visit the Civil Service Commission website for further information: <https://civilservicecommission.independent.gov.uk>

